

China Payment & Apps Setup Guide

A printable pre-arrival setup pack for Alipay, WeChat Pay, essential apps, maps, translation, ride-hailing, internet access, backup payment options, and first-day troubleshooting.

Mobile-readable. Printable. Built for first-time foreign visitors preparing for China.

Use this guide for	What this guide is not
Planning your first payment, app, internet, and backup setup before arrival.	Legal, immigration, visa, financial, banking, or official government advice.

[Start here](#)

How to use this setup guide

Work through the pages before you fly, then keep the phrase cards and offline notes on your phone. Availability may change, so use this as a practical planning layer and verify important rules in the official app or provider source.

When	What to do	Why it matters
7-14 days before	Install apps, add cards, choose data plan, save hotel address.	You have time to solve verification and bank security prompts.
2-3 days before	Reopen apps, update passwords, save screenshots, pack backup card and cash.	Travel day is not the moment to debug account access.
Arrival day	Test data, maps, translation, payment, ride-hailing, and hotel address.	Small tests reduce stress before the first meal or taxi.
First 48 hours	Use simple purchases, keep backups nearby, ask hotel staff for address help.	Most friction is easier to solve away from queues.

Important travel disclaimer

First China Trip Kit provides travel planning information only. We do not provide legal, immigration, visa, financial, banking, or official government advice. Visa rules, payment app support, bank card acceptance, transport policies, and booking requirements may change. Always verify current official requirements before booking or traveling.

Your setup timeline

☐	Confirm your passport, visa or visa-free transit eligibility, and entry documents through official sources.
☐	Install Alipay and WeChat before departure and confirm you can sign in.
☐	Add at least one international card to Alipay if supported for your account and card issuer.
☐	Prepare WeChat Pay as a backup if your account and card setup allow it.
☐	Choose roaming, eSIM, local SIM, or pocket Wi-Fi before arrival.
☐	Save your hotel name, Chinese address, phone number, and nearest landmark offline.
☐	Save passport copy, flight details, train tickets, attraction bookings, and insurance offline.
☐	Carry a physical card and a small cash backup for arrival-day problems.
☐	Prepare translation, maps, and ride-hailing access before the first transfer.

Payment setup master checklist

Layer	Prepare	Use for	Backup note
Alipay	Install, sign in, add card, learn scan/show QR flows.	Everyday payments, ride-hailing, some local travel services.	Do not rely on one card only if you can add another.
WeChat Pay	Prepare if your account supports it.	Restaurants, mini programs, local contact flows.	Treat as a backup until tested.
Physical card	Keep the card used for hotels and bookings.	Hotel deposits, international hotels, emergency backup.	Some small merchants may not accept it.
Cash	Carry a modest amount in RMB.	Arrival-day gaps, phone battery issues, small merchant backup.	China is mobile-payment heavy, but cash can still help.
Hotel help	Ask staff to confirm addresses or write a short note.	Taxi, station, booking, and payment explanation support.	Useful when translation is not enough.

Prepare a backup

Payment app availability, foreign card support, merchant QR flows, and bank security rules may change. Keep more than one payment path ready.

Alipay setup checklist

☐	Install the official Alipay app from your phone's app store.
☐	Sign in with a phone number you can access while traveling.
☐	Use the same passport name format when identity details are requested.
☐	Add your main international card if supported.
☐	Add a backup card from a different bank if possible.
☐	Learn the two QR patterns: scan merchant code and show your payment code.
☐	Enable phone security you can use while traveling, such as passcode or biometrics.
☐	Keep mobile data active before opening payment, map, or ride-hailing flows.
☐	Test with a small low-pressure purchase before relying on Alipay for a full day.

If setup fails

Do not solve every account issue at a busy counter. Step aside, try stable Wi-Fi, use a backup card or cash for urgent purchases, and ask hotel staff for practical help.

WeChat Pay setup checklist

☐	Install WeChat and confirm you can sign in before travel day.
☐	Prepare account security and phone access before departure.
☐	Open wallet/payment features only if they are available for your account.
☐	Add your card if supported and complete only ordinary app prompts.
☐	Do not make WeChat Pay your only payment plan on a first trip.
☐	Use WeChat Pay where a restaurant, local service, or mini program flow needs it.
☐	Test with a small purchase before using it for a taxi, meal, or ticket line.
☐	Keep Alipay, physical card, and cash available as backups.

Good WeChat Pay use case	Use another backup when
A restaurant ordering system opens inside WeChat.	Your account asks for extra verification you cannot complete.
A local contact or mini program expects WeChat.	You are standing in a queue with weak mobile data.
A merchant QR flow works better in WeChat.	The purchase is urgent and cash or Alipay is faster.

Backup payment decision tree

Problem	First move	Second move	Fallback
Merchant QR will not load	Check mobile data and try again.	Ask if cashier can scan your payment code.	Use another wallet or cash.
Card issuer blocks payment	Try backup card if already added.	Use cash or physical card for urgent purchase.	Call issuer later on stable Wi-Fi.
App asks for verification	Step aside and read the prompt calmly.	Use hotel Wi-Fi or ask staff for translation help.	Use another payment path.
Taxi payment unclear	Use ride-hailing inside an app if possible.	Show hotel address and ask about cash before ride.	Ask hotel staff to help arrange taxi.
Restaurant QR ordering fails	Ask staff for help or cashier ordering.	Choose picture menu or counter ordering.	Move to a simpler first meal.

Decision rule

If the purchase is urgent, pay with the working backup first. Debug app and card problems later, away from the counter.

Essential China apps stack

Need	Primary app type	Prepare before arrival	Offline backup
Payment	Alipay plus WeChat if available	Install, sign in, add card, learn QR flows.	Cash, physical card, screenshot notes.
Maps	Apple Maps, Amap, or Baidu Maps	Save hotel and station names in Chinese.	Screenshots of routes and addresses.
Translation	Text, camera, and offline Chinese	Download offline language pack if offered.	Saved phrase cards.
Ride-hailing	DiDi or ride-hailing mini program	Save hotel address and pickup notes.	Taxi card and cash backup.
Trains	12306 or travel platform	Save passport-linked booking details.	Screenshots of train number, station, carriage.
Internet	Roaming, eSIM, local SIM, or pocket Wi-Fi	Choose plan and test instructions.	Airport Wi-Fi and hotel help.

Mobile data and access checklist

☐	Confirm your phone supports your chosen roaming, eSIM, SIM, or pocket Wi-Fi option.
☐	Save activation instructions offline before the flight.
☐	Keep your home SIM or phone number accessible if apps or banks send security prompts.
☐	Download offline Chinese in your translation app if available.
☐	Save key map pins, station names, hotel address, and booking details as screenshots.
☐	Before leaving the airport or station, test data, maps, translation, payment apps, and ride-hailing.
☐	Carry a power bank so payment and transport apps are not limited by battery.

Option	Best for	Watch for
Roaming	Simple short trips if your home plan is affordable.	Daily fees, speed limits, and coverage.
Travel eSIM	Phones that support eSIM and travelers who want setup before landing.	Activation timing and mainland China support.
Local SIM	Longer stays and travelers who need local service.	Passport registration and setup time.
Pocket Wi-Fi	Groups sharing one connection.	Battery, pickup/return, and carrying another device.

First-day payment test

☐	Open Alipay and confirm the app loads on mobile data.
☐	Open WeChat and confirm you can access chat and payment features if available.
☐	Load your hotel address in Chinese and map pin.
☐	Make one small low-pressure purchase, such as bottled water or a snack.
☐	If one card fails, try a backup card or another wallet before troubleshooting in depth.
☐	Use ride-hailing or hotel help for your first taxi if the destination is hard to explain.
☐	Keep cash, physical card, passport, and hotel address accessible on the first day.
☐	Write down what worked: wallet, card, merchant type, and any prompts you saw.

Good first purchase

Choose a calm shop near your hotel or a staffed counter. Avoid making your first test while a taxi meter is running or a restaurant line is waiting.

Common payment failure fixes

Symptom	Likely cause	What to try
Payment app opens slowly	Weak mobile data or app update.	Step aside, reconnect, reopen app, use screenshot notes.
Card cannot be charged	Issuer security or merchant support.	Try backup card, lower-pressure merchant, cash, or physical card.
QR scan does nothing	Wrong QR type or mini program issue.	Ask cashier to scan your payment code instead.
Identity prompt appears	Account verification required.	Read prompt, use stable Wi-Fi, avoid sharing sensitive data with strangers.
Restaurant ordering QR is confusing	Menu flow requires local language or account.	Ask staff for help, use camera translation, or order at counter.
Taxi driver does not understand address	Address not saved in Chinese.	Show hotel card with Chinese address and phone number.
Train booking details hard to find	App login or data issue.	Use passport, screenshots, and staffed counter if needed.

Taxi and checkout phrases

Situation	Show this Chinese	Pinyin	Meaning
Taxi to hotel	请带我去这个地址。	Qing dai wo qu zhe ge di zhi.	Please take me to this address.
Call hotel	可以帮我打电话给酒店吗？	Ke yi bang wo da dian hua gei jiu dian ma?	Can you help call the hotel?
Alipay	可以用支付宝吗？	Ke yi yong Zhi Fu Bao ma?	Can I use Alipay?
WeChat Pay	可以用微信支付吗？	Ke yi yong Wei Xin Zhi Fu ma?	Can I use WeChat Pay?
Cash	可以用现金吗？	Ke yi yong xian jin ma?	Can I use cash?
Need help	我不会操作，可以帮我一下吗？	Wo bu hui cao zuo, ke yi bang wo yi xia ma?	I do not know how to use this. Can you help?
Receipt	可以给我收据吗？	Ke yi gei wo shou ju ma?	Can I have a receipt?

How to use phrases

Show the Chinese characters on your screen. Short written Chinese is often clearer than long spoken audio in a busy taxi, shop, or restaurant.

Print or save these cards

Hotel address card	Hotel name: _____ Chinese address: _____ Phone: _____ Nearest landmark: _____
Payment backup card	Main wallet: _____ Backup wallet: _____ Backup card: _____ Cash location: _____
Transport card	Arrival airport/station: _____ Hotel route: _____ Backup taxi phrase saved: Yes / No
Emergency card	Travel insurance: _____ Embassy/consulate info: _____ Hotel front desk phone: _____

First 24 hours in China

☐	Confirm phone data works outside the airport or station.
☐	Open maps and confirm your hotel route.
☐	Open translation app and camera translation.
☐	Confirm hotel address and phone number are saved in Chinese.
☐	Test one payment app with a small purchase.
☐	Keep cash and physical card available until payment is tested.
☐	Save screenshots of any app prompts that need later attention.
☐	Ask hotel staff to confirm station, attraction, or taxi addresses before long transfers.
☐	Avoid tight train, flight, or attraction schedules on the first day.
☐	Rest, charge devices, and prepare the next morning's transport plan.

Official verification reminders

Topic	Verify before relying on it	Where to check
Entry documents	Visa, visa-free transit, passport validity, permitted stay area.	Official consular or immigration sources.
Payment apps	Current foreign card support, fees, identity prompts, and usage limits.	Official app help pages and in-app notices.
Transport	Ticket rules, station name, passport checks, refund or change policy.	Official railway or booking platform details.
Attractions	Reservation rules, passport requirements, closure days, entry time.	Official attraction pages or booking mini programs.
Mobile data	Plan coverage, activation timing, speed, and mainland China support.	Your mobile provider or eSIM provider.

Keep this wording in mind

Availability may change. Prepare a backup. Verify official requirements. This guide helps you plan, but it does not replace current official instructions.

Final pre-flight checklist

☐	Passport and entry documents verified.
☐	Hotel Chinese address and phone number saved offline.
☐	Alipay installed, signed in, and prepared if available.
☐	WeChat and WeChat Pay prepared as a backup if available.
☐	Payment backup card and cash plan ready.
☐	Mobile data option chosen and instructions saved offline.
☐	Maps, translation, ride-hailing, and train support apps prepared.
☐	First-day small payment test planned.
☐	Taxi and checkout phrase cards saved to phone.
☐	Important screenshots stored in an offline album.
☐	Official requirements checked before final bookings.

Need help?

If you cannot access your guide or purchased the wrong file, contact hello@firstchinatripkit.com and we will review the issue.